INDIA, A RESEARCH LAB

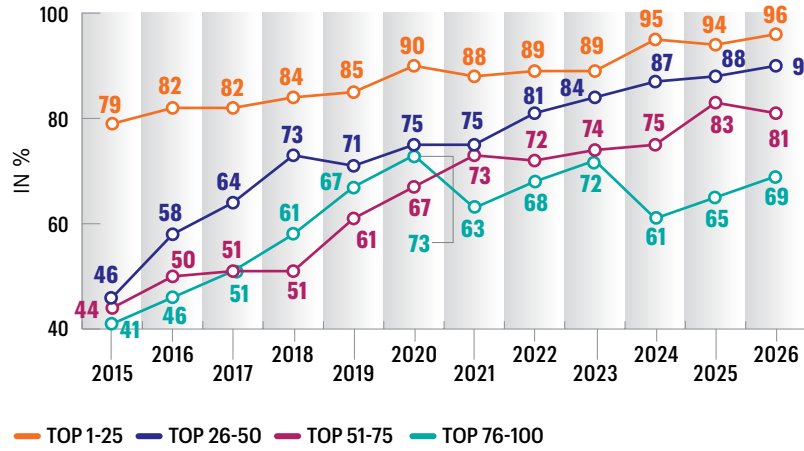
India's fast-expanding consumer economy, dense urban markets, flexible workforce and fast-growing digital infrastructure trigger questions that are locally important as well as academically significant.

Sobhanan's research looks at last-mile delivery, workload equity for gig workers and warehouse operators, the areas where Indian businesses are grappling with questions of cost, speed, reliability and scale. "Many underlying decisions—how to route a fleet, allocate work across delivery partners, run a warehouse floor—are still made with simple rules or intuition," he says. For a researcher trained in mathematical methods, this creates an opportunity to work on academic models with direct commercial relevance. The field is wide, with Indian B-schools working on diverse areas such as AI, sustainability, digital transformation, healthcare, entrepreneurship and future of work.

Sebastian MP, Dean (Faculty Administration & Development) at IIM Kozhikode, describes a shift towards a more interdisciplinary and globally connected faculty, with management scholars increasingly combining their traditional disciplines with data science, AI, psychology, sociology, public policy, climate science, design and engineering.

RESEARCH TAKES CENTRE STAGE

• **96% faculty in top 25 B-schools is a PhD now**



SOURCE *BT*-MDRA B-SCHOOL SURVEYS

THE YOUNG ADVANTAGE

A younger faculty does not automatically mean better faculty. Experience, institutional knowledge and academic mentorship remain critical. The emerging model is, therefore, less about replacing senior professors than creating a stronger mix of generations.

"They (the younger faculty) are good at research and publication. This benefits the ecosystem, because they will train our PhD students. Even some senior faculty, including people like us, learn a lot by listening to them. So, that is a huge advantage for the institute when it comes to research and publication."

But that also creates a need for contextual understanding. Mukherji points to an area where the younger, internationally trained faculty may need support: teaching. "A significant part of an IIM's income comes from executive education where we conduct three-day or five-day programmes for top executives. These executives need contextual understanding. You cannot present a theoretical model. You have to relate it to their context."

RATIO OF PERMANENT TO VISITING FACULTY

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Top 1 - 25	58:42	58:42	53:47	58:42	56:44	58:42	63:37	60:40	64:36	62:38	68:32	67:33
Top 26 - 50	52:48	50:50	57:43	64:36	57:43	58:42	57:43	56:44	58:42	63:37	64:36	63:37
Top 51 - 75	60:40	59:41	60:40	55:45	53:47	63:37	60:40	61:39	62:38	63:37	65:35	67:33
Top 76 - 100	62:38	63:37	60:40	56:44	68:32	61:39	67:33	63:37	64:36	66:34	69:31	77:23

IN %; **SOURCE** BT-MDRA B-SCHOOL SURVEYS